Ice age!

Imagine a world in which ice extends farther than the Arctic and Antarctic—a world in which ice sheets cover large chunks of North America, Europe, and Asia. At times, much of the Earth's surface has been covered by sheets of ice. These periods of Earth's history are known as its ice ages, with glaciers a prominent feature.

▲ AN EARLY VIEW *A nineteenth century artwork by a Swedish geologist and naturalist, Oswald Heer, provided an unrealistic picture of large mammals, including mammoths and deer, surviving at the edges of the last ice age. In reality, these mammals lived on steppes (grasslands).*

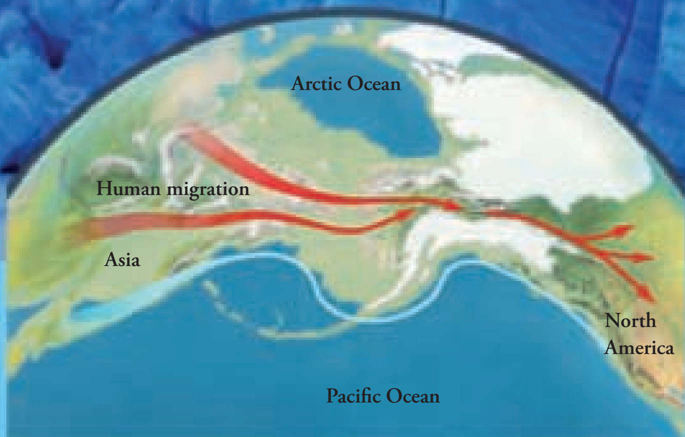
WHAT IS A GLACIER?

A glacier is a slow-moving river of ice, forced to move downhill by its weight. It can be enormous. In an ice age, Earth's temperature varies, with glaciers pushing forward over land during the cold periods (known as glacial periods) and retreating in warmer periods (interglacial periods).

Snowball Earth

Over millions of years, Earth has moved from warm periods to cold periods and back to warm periods. Scientists don't know what triggers an ice age, but think it has something to do with gradual changes in the Earth's orbit around the Sun over millions of years.

During the most severe ice ages, Earth was entirely covered in ice.



An unusual route opens

During an ice age, sea levels fall by as much as 300 ft (100 m) as water becomes locked up on land as ice, instead of flowing out to sea in rivers. As the sea falls, new land appears, sometimes forming a bridge between continents or islands. During the last ice age, land bridges joined Britain to Europe, New Guinea to Australia, and Siberia to Alaska, allowing people to cross from Asia to North America.